

Firing on All Cylinders

■ By Yogendra Pratap

Not surprisingly, the hype and hoopla over the launch of Tata's small car has virtually obscured the fact that 2008 is going to be a year when a host of exciting new cars will hit the Indian auto market. Turbocharged by the positive signals for the automobile sector, no less than 30 new models will make their debut on Indian roads from marquees ranging from BMW, Mercedes, Audi and Volvo in the luxury segment to premium sedans from Volkswagen, Toyota, Honda and Fiat, while the market will also see the largest number of small car launches. Along with the SUVs and MUVs, anyone planning to buy a new car or upgrade will be spoilt for choice. Adding to this will be a number of facelifts, new engines and variants, so the options could well be close to the three-figure mark.

In fact, 2008 is poised to revolutionise the Indian auto industry like never before. It will be the year of dieselisation as Bosch ramps up production of its made-in-India common

rail direct injection kits and also readies systems for the ultra-small capacity diesel engines. The Fiat-Tata Motors engine plant will go on-stream later in the year and the Maruti Suzuki diesel engine plant will be running for its first full calendar year.

So appropriately, it's worth looking at the calendar girls, or the auto equivalent. The hot new launches will be spearheaded by the Germans, with the Volkswagen Group leading the way. With all the group car assembly operations being consolidated at Aurangabad and the work on the Pune plant well underway, VW is all set to blaze a trail in India. Skoda-Auto is entering the mass market segment for the first time, while Audi is consolidating its base with an expanding network and introduction of more India-assembled cars in addition to the A6. VW itself will be launching a number of premium products until its manufacturing facilities are ready. BMW already has assembly going ahead at full steam at Chennai with a sizeable order list and is now looking at introducing more of its pure performance cars,

LARGE HATCHBACKS



TATA INDICA V3 ▲

Rs 3.5-5.5 lakh (approx)

Specifications: 1.4 petrol, 80 bhp;

1.3 multijet diesel, 75 bhp;

1.5-litre DICOR

USP: Contemporarily-designed Indica with larger proportions. Interiors spruced up with centre-mounted instrumentation. Multijet diesel engines from Fiat will make the V3 a pleasure to drive.

To compete with: Chevrolet Aveo U-VA, Hyundai Getz Prime, Suzuki Swift

SUZUKI SPLASH ▼

Rs 4 lakh (approx)

Specifications: 1-litre, 60 bhp, 3-cylinder petrol; 1.2-litre, 85 bhp, 4-cylinder petrol;

1.3-litre, 75 bhp, 4-cylinder diesel

USP: Replacement of the Wagon-R.

Retains the advantages of an MPV while looking like a car. High seating, feeling of space and flexibility with all the features of higher-end cars.

To compete with: Hyundai Getz, Mahindra-Renault Logan, Ford Ikon and Suzuki Swift.



SMALL CARS



▲ SUZUKI A-STAR

Rs 3 lakh (approx)

Specifications: 1 litre all aluminium engine, 60 bhp

USP: Maruti's new small car is developed for India by Indians. Will be stylish, fuel-efficient and environment friendly with contemporary features.

To compete with: Hyundai Santro and i10